

In the Matter of)
)
Amendment of Part 97 of the Commission's) RM-____
Rules to Authorize Expanded Special Event)
Amateur Radio Call Sign Formats)
)

To: The Secretary, Federal Communications Commission
Via: Office of the Secretary / ECFS
Attn: Chief, Wireless Telecommunications Bureau, Mobility Division

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I. INTRODUCTION AND SUMMARY OF THE ARGUMENT

1. For eighty years, the amateur radio service has served as a proving ground for radio operators, a resource for emergency communications, and a form of goodwill diplomacy between the United States and other nations. A central feature of that service — in the United States and abroad — is the "special event station": a temporary, thematically named call sign that amateur clubs and individuals use to commemorate anniversaries, expositions, disaster-relief operations, and other events of public significance.

2. Since 1997, the Commission's rules have permitted U.S. amateur licensees to use special event call signs, but *only* in the exceptionally narrow "1x1" format — a single letter (K, N, or W), a single digit, and a single letter (e.g., "W1A").¹ That 750-combination block was carved out in 1994-95 specifically because it was the *least* commercially useful and thus *least* costly format the Commission could set aside without depleting the sequential and vanity call sign systems used for permanent station licensing.²

3. In the three decades since, every comparable ITU member administration this Petitioner could identify with verifiable primary-source documentation — the United Kingdom, Canada, Australia, Germany, Ireland, and Japan — has adopted special event call sign systems that permit substantially longer, more flexible, and more thematically expressive suffixes than the United States' 1x1 format, while preserving the same administrative safeguards (coordinator or agency issuance, defined time limits, and mandatory identification

¹ 47 C.F.R. § 97.3(a)(11)(iii).

² *Amendment of Part 97 of the Commission's Amateur Service Rules*, Report and Order, PR Docket No. 93-305, 10 FCC Rcd 1039, ¶ 13 (1995).

with the licensee's assigned call sign).³ The International Telecommunication Union's own Radio Regulations expressly anticipate and authorize this practice: Article 19, No. 19.68A, added at the 2003 World Radiocommunication Conference, provides that "[o]n special occasions, for temporary use, administrations may authorize use of call signs with more than the four characters" otherwise specified for amateur stations.⁴

4. The United States is consequently an outlier. This Petition asks the Commission to exercise the discretion Congress and the ITU Radio Regulations already afford it, and to amend Part 97 to authorize a second, longer special event call sign format — administered through the same certified coordinator system that has managed the 1x1 block without incident since 1997 — and to make that format available for amateur radio contest operation as well, whether or not a contest coincides with a special event, bringing U.S. practice into alignment with the rest of the world.

II. STATEMENT OF INTEREST OF PETITIONER

5. Petitioner is a federally licensed amateur radio operator whose interests, and those of the broader amateur radio community, are directly and adversely affected by the current rule. The scarcity and rigidity of the 1x1 format frequently prevents clubs and event organizers from obtaining a call sign that meaningfully identifies the event being commemorated (for example, a numeral marking a specific anniversary, as is now common practice abroad), forcing organizers either to accept an arbitrary, non-descriptive 1x1 combination or to forgo a special event call sign altogether. Petitioner has a direct interest in the Commission adopting a rule that permits more expressive, internationally consistent special event call signs.

³ See Section V, *infra*, and sources cited therein.

⁴ ITU Radio Regulations, Article 19, No. 19.68A (added World Radiocommunication Conference 2003).

III. BACKGROUND: THE CURRENT REGULATORY FRAMEWORK

A. The Amateur Service Call Sign System Generally

6. The Commission's amateur radio call sign systems are set out in 47 C.F.R. §§ 97.3 and 97.19, and are administered under the Commission's general licensing authority in the Communications Act of 1934, as amended, 47 U.S.C. §§ 151-155, 301-609.⁵ Amateur stations are ordinarily assigned "sequential" call signs by the Universal Licensing System, or may apply for a "vanity" call sign under 47 C.F.R. § 97.19, corresponding to formats (informally referred to by the Commission's licensing staff as Groups A through D) tied to the applicant's license class.⁶

B. Origin and Scope of the 1x1 Special Event Call Sign System

7. Separate from the vanity system, 47 C.F.R. § 97.3(a)(11)(iii) defines a "special event call sign system" under which a station licensee may substitute, for the period of a "self-determined special event," a call sign selected from a common database "coordinated, maintained and disseminated by the amateur station special event call sign data base coordinators." The rule fixes the format precisely: "a single letter prefix K, N or W, followed by a single numeral 0 through 9, followed by a single letter A through W or Y or Z (for example K1A)."⁷ Section 97.119(d) permits a station to identify using this substitute call sign, provided the station also transmits its regularly assigned call sign at least once per hour.⁸

⁵ 47 U.S.C. §§ 151-155, 301-609; see also authority citation to 47 C.F.R. Part 97, 48 Stat. 1066, 1082, as amended; 47 U.S.C. §§ 154, 303.

⁶ 47 C.F.R. § 97.19. The "Group A/B/C/D" terminology is used in the Commission's public licensing guidance (e.g., FCC, *Amateur Call Sign Systems*, <https://www.fcc.gov/wireless/bureau-divisions/mobility-division/amateur-radio-service/amateur-call-sign-systems> (last visited Sept. 16, 2026)) rather than in the text of § 97.19 itself.

⁷ 47 C.F.R. § 97.3(a)(11)(iii).

⁸ 47 C.F.R. § 97.119(d).

8. This system originates in two Commission orders. First, in a Report and Order in PR Docket No. 93-305, the Commission reserved the block of "750 one-by-one call signs" — the rarest and least commercially valuable call sign format under the U.S. system — for temporary use during events of special significance to the amateur community.⁹ Second, in *Amendment of Part 97 of the Commission's Rules Concerning Amateur Radio Service*, FCC 97-99, WT Docket No. 95-57 (adopted March 20, 1997; released April 1, 1997), the Commission codified that reservation into the current rule text and delegated administration of the special event call sign database to Commission-certified volunteer "coordinators" under 47 C.F.R. § 0.131(p).¹⁰ The Commission's stated rationale for confining the format to the 1x1 block was one of scarcity: "we do not have additional call signs to assign for this purpose given that any such call signs would have to be taken from the sequential and vanity call sign systems, thus denying them to amateur operators who want them assigned to their primary and club stations."¹¹

9. That rationale — a zero-sum competition between special event call signs and the finite pool of sequential/vanity formats — does not describe the rule change proposed here. As explained in Section VI, *infra*, the format this Petition proposes would be created and administered in the same manner as the existing 1x1 block: a wholly new, non-permanent, coordinator-issued category that does not draw down the sequential or vanity call sign pools at all.

⁹ *Amendment of Part 97 of the Commission's Amateur Service Rules*, Report and Order, PR Docket No. 93-305, 10 FCC Rcd 1039, ¶ 13 (1995).

¹⁰ *Amendment of Part 97 of the Commission's Rules Concerning Amateur Radio Service*, Report and Order, FCC 97-99, WT Docket No. 95-57, ¶¶ 12-16 (adopted Mar. 20, 1997; released Apr. 1, 1997) (consolidating RM-8301, RM-8418, and RM-8462); 47 C.F.R. § 0.131(p).

¹¹ FCC 97-99, WT Docket No. 95-57, ¶ 16.

C. The Commission Has Already Been Asked to Do This — and Never Ruled on the Request

10. This is not the first time the idea proposed here has been placed before the Commission. In comments filed March 26, 2010, in WT Docket No. 09-209 — a proceeding concerning vanity and club station call sign rules generally — the American Radio Relay League ("ARRL"), the amateur service's principal national association, recommended that the Commission take up, "in a later, separate proceeding, but soon," an amendment to 47 C.F.R. § 97.3(a)(11)(iii) to expand the special event call sign format beyond the single 1x1 block. ARRL grounded that recommendation in the same 2003 World Radiocommunication Conference amendment to ITU Radio Regulations No. 19.68 discussed in Section IV, *infra*, and observed that "[i]t is time to reexamine this program to determine where deregulatory changes can be implemented to increase flexibility in the program."¹² The Commission's ensuing Report and Order in that docket, FCC 10-189 (released Nov. 8, 2010), addressed vanity call sign reassignment timing and club station license procedures, but did not address, adopt, or deny ARRL's special event call sign suggestion in any respect.¹³ The suggestion appears simply to have gone unaddressed in a docket devoted to other issues, rather than having been considered and rejected on the merits. This Petition formalizes, and requests a ruling on, that sixteen-year-old, previously unaddressed proposal.

11. A fresh Petition for Rulemaking is the only procedural vehicle now available to obtain that ruling. ARRL's special event call sign suggestion — offered as a passing

¹² Comments of ARRL, the National Association for Amateur Radio, WT Docket No. 09-209, ¶ 22 (filed Mar. 26, 2010).

¹³ *Amendment of the Amateur Service Rules Governing Vanity and Club Station Call Signs*, Report and Order, FCC 10-189, WT Docket No. 09-209, 25 FCC Rcd 16351 (released Nov. 8, 2010); see ARRL, *FCC Issues Report and Order on Vanity and Club Station Call Signs* (Nov. 10, 2010), <https://www.arrl.org/news/fcc-issues-em-report-and-order-em-on-vanity-and-club-station-call-signs> (last visited Sept. 16, 2026) (no mention of special event call signs in the Report and Order).

recommendation for future action within comments filed on an unrelated NPRM — was never itself the subject of a request pending in WT Docket No. 09-209 for the Commission to grant or deny. ARRL did separately petition for reconsideration of FCC 10-189, but only as to unrelated club-station vanity call sign limits; that petition did not raise the special event call sign format, and the Commission's order resolving it did not address that format either.¹⁴ In denying ARRL's petition, the Commission expressly terminated WT Docket No. 09-209.¹⁵ Nor is reconsideration available today: a petition for reconsideration must be filed "within 30 days from the date of public notice of the final Commission action," 47 C.F.R. § 1.106(f), and that window closed in early 2012. With the docket formally terminated and the reconsideration window closed for over a decade, the only avenue by which the Commission can now be asked to act on the special event call sign proposal is a new petition under 47 C.F.R. § 1.401 — precisely the vehicle Petitioner invokes here.

12. Petitioner notes, again in the interest of candor, that ARRL's reconsideration petition also expressed disagreement with the Commission's earlier decision not to adopt a separate ARRL suggestion to increase the number of call signs available in certain sequential and vanity formats generally. The Commission responded that it had "no plans to revisit the issue at this time," but ARRL did not request reconsideration of that point and the Commission's order did not treat it as one.¹⁶ That exchange concerned the availability of combinations within the existing, permanent sequential and vanity formats — the same

¹⁴ *Amendment of the Amateur Service Rules Governing Vanity and Club Station Call Signs*, Memorandum Opinion and Order, FCC 12-1, WT Docket No. 09-209, ¶¶ 1-2 & nn.1-2 (adopted Jan. 3, 2012; released Jan. 11, 2012) (denying American Radio Relay League, Inc., Petition for Partial Reconsideration (filed Jan. 13, 2011), which addressed only club station license and call sign limits and did not raise the special event call sign format).

¹⁵ FCC 12-1, WT Docket No. 09-209, ¶ 10 ("IT IS FURTHER ORDERED that proceeding WT Docket No. 09-209 IS HEREBY TERMINATED.").

¹⁶ FCC 12-1, WT Docket No. 09-209, n.10 (noting that ARRL "expresses disagreement with, but does not request reconsideration of, the Commission's decision not to adopt ARRL's suggestions to increase the number of call signs available in certain formats," and that "we have no plans to revisit the issue at this time").

general topic later raised in the 2017 Alessi petition discussed below — and neither the exchange nor the Commission's response addressed, or purports to resolve, the distinct question presented here: whether the temporary, coordinator-administered special event system should be permitted a second, longer format.

13. Petitioner further notes, for the sake of completeness and candor, that the Commission denied one earlier petition for reconsideration of the original special event call sign order: a petition filed by David B. Popkin, denied in *Amendments to the Amateur Service Rules*, Memorandum Opinion and Order, FCC 99-84, WT Docket No. 95-57, 14 FCC Rcd 8812 (1999). That petition sought only administrative changes to the special event call sign system — a requirement to identify at the end of a continuous series of transmissions, a fifteen-day maximum duration, a thirty-day interval before reuse of a call sign, codification of first-come-first-served, non-discriminatory, no-charge assignment by the coordinators, and a prohibition on compensation to coordinators for their services. It did not seek, and the Commission's order does not address, any change to the call sign format itself. FCC 99-84 accordingly provides no basis to deny, and is not adverse to, the format-expansion proposal made here.¹⁷

D. Neither the 2017 Alessi Petition Nor the 2019 Dukish Petition Is Controlling

14. Separately, in 2017, an individual petitioner sought to make a new "1×1" format (a letter, followed by two digits, followed by a letter) generally available to Amateur Extra Class licensees as an alternative *permanent, sequential/vanity* call sign format, citing a perceived shortage of desirable 1x2 and 2x1 combinations. The Bureau dismissed that petition by letter, citing the roughly 15 million sequential call signs already available and an

¹⁷ *Amendments to the Amateur Service Rules Including Amendments for Examination Credit, Eligibility for a Club Station License, Recognition of the Volunteer Examiner Session Manager, a Special Event Call Sign System and a Self-Assigned Indicator in the Station Identification*, Memorandum Opinion and Order, FCC 99-84, WT Docket No. 95-57, 14 FCC Rcd 8812 (adopted Apr. 26, 1999; released Apr. 30, 1999) (denying Petition for Reconsideration of David B. Popkin, filed May 1, 1997).

unspecified, similarly-reasoned petition rejected in 2010.¹⁸ That petition addressed the *permanent* vanity call sign system and a claimed scarcity that the Bureau found factually unsupported — an entirely different rule section and rationale from the one at issue here. It did not address, and is not applicable to, the distinct question presented in this Petition: whether the *temporary*, coordinator-administered special event system — which by definition does not compete with the permanent call sign pool — should be permitted a second, longer format. Nor is the 2019 denial of a station-identification-timing petition unrelated to call sign format, RM-11826, applicable here; that petition sought an identification-timing exception for emergency nets under § 97.119(a), an unrelated subsection.¹⁹ Apart from the unresolved 1999 order noted in paragraph 13, above, Petitioner is not aware of any FCC order denying, on the merits, a request to expand the special event call sign format itself, and no reported judicial decision addresses amateur call sign format policy; the only governing authority is the agency's own orders discussed above.

IV. INTERNATIONAL LAW CONFIRMS THE COMMISSION'S DISCRETION TO ADOPT LONGER SPECIAL EVENT CALL SIGNS

15. The United States' amateur call signs are drawn from international call sign series allocated to it under Appendix 42 to the ITU Radio Regulations (the blocks AAA-ALZ, KAA-KZZ, NAA-NZZ, and WAA-WZZ).²⁰ Article 19 of the Radio Regulations governs how those series may be used.²¹ Two provisions are directly relevant.

¹⁸ Letter from Scot Stone, Deputy Chief, Mobility Division, Wireless Telecommunications Bureau, FCC, to Thomas J. Alessi (Nov. 28, 2017), *reported in* ARRL, *FCC Dismisses Radio Amateur's Petition to Revise Call Sign Rules* (Dec. 2017), <https://www.arrl.org/news/fcc-dismisses-radio-amateur-s-petition-to-revise-call-sign-rules> (last visited Sept. 16, 2026).

¹⁹ *Robert Dukish*, Order, RM-11826 (Wireless Telecomm. Bur., Mobility Div.), *summarized in* FCC, *Robert Dukish Rulemaking Petition Decision*, <https://www.fcc.gov/document/robert-dukish-rulemaking-petition-decision> (last visited Sept. 16, 2026); ARRL news coverage of RM-11826 (2018-2019).

²⁰ ITU Radio Regulations, Appendix 42, Table of Allocation of International Call Sign Series.

²¹ ITU Radio Regulations, Article 19 (Identification of Stations).

16. First, No. 19.38 provides that "[e]ach administration shall choose the call signs from the international series allocated or supplied to it," and expressly excludes call signs assigned to amateur stations from the notification requirements that apply to other services.²² The ITU accordingly leaves the assignment of amateur call signs — including special event call signs — entirely to the discretion of the national administration; the Commission need not seek any international clearance to adopt the rule proposed here.

17. Second, and most directly on point, No. 19.68 sets a baseline format for amateur call signs (a nationality prefix, a digit other than 0 or 1, and up to four further characters ending in a letter). No. 19.68A, added by the 2003 World Radiocommunication Conference, then creates the specific carve-out this Petition invokes: "On special occasions, for temporary use, administrations may authorize use of call signs with more than the four characters referred to in No. 19.68."²³ The Radio Regulations — a binding international treaty to which the United States is a party — thus expressly contemplate and authorize exactly the kind of extended, temporary, special-occasion call sign this Petition requests. The Commission's current 1x1-only rule is more restrictive than international law requires; it is a matter of domestic policy choice, not treaty obligation.

V. COMPARATIVE PRACTICE: OTHER ADMINISTRATIONS ALREADY AUTHORIZE LONGER SPECIAL EVENT CALL SIGNS

18. Exercising the very discretion described above, a number of ITU member administrations comparable to the United States already authorize special event call signs substantially longer and more flexible than the U.S. 1x1 format. Table 1 below summarizes verified practice in six jurisdictions:

²² ITU Radio Regulations, Article 19, No. 19.38.

²³ ITU Radio Regulations, Article 19, Nos. 19.68, 19.68A.

Table 1. Comparative Special Event Call Sign Practices in Selected ITU Member Administrations

Country	Regulator	Administration model	Format	Typical duration	Fee
United Kingdom	Ofcom	Issued directly by Ofcom (RSGB advisory only) ²⁴	"GB" (and related) prefixes with 2-3 letter suffixes; an extended "Special SES" format permits longer, numeral-bearing suffixes for major anniversaries (e.g., "GB100XYZ") ²⁵	Up to 28 days per Notice of Variation	No fee identified

²⁴ Ofcom, *Applying for Special Event Station Notice of Variations Online*, <https://www.ofcom.org.uk/spectrum/radio-equipment/applying-for-special-event-station-notice-of-variations-online> (last visited Sept. 16, 2026); Radio Society of Great Britain (RSGB), *Applying for a Special Event Station*, <https://rsgb.org/main/operating/licensing-novs-visitors/applying-for-a-special-event-station/> (last visited Sept. 16, 2026).

²⁵ RSGB, *Ofcom Implements Phases 2 and 3 of the Amateur Radio Licence Review* (Oct. 17, 2025), <https://rsgb.org/main/blog/news/gb2rs/headlines/2025/10/17/ofcom-implements-phases-2-and-3-of-the-amateur-radio-licence-review/> (last visited Sept. 16, 2026).

Country	Regulator	Administration model	Format	Typical duration	Fee
Canada	Innovation, Science and Economic Development Canada (ISED)	Issued directly by ISED's Amateur Radio Service Centre, in a four-category system (RIC-9) ²⁶	Special prefixes (e.g., "CG" substituted for "VE") combined with single-letter or up to four-character alphanumeric suffixes reserved exclusively for special event use ²⁷	2 weeks to 60 days depending on category	CAD \$60.00 per occurrence ²⁸
Australia	Australian Communications and Media Authority (ACMA)	Issued directly by ACMA; "VI" prefix restricted to club applicants ²⁹	"VI" substituted for "VK," combined with a thematic suffix of more than four characters	Short-term licence tied to the event, renewable	AUD \$56 (initial application) / \$36 (reassignment), effective Aug. 9, 2025 ³⁰

²⁶ Innovation, Science and Economic Development Canada, Radiocommunication Information Circular RIC-9, *Call Sign Policy and Special Event Prefixes*, Issue 2 (Oct. 2005).

²⁷ RIC-9, §§ 1.3.2, 2.2.

²⁸ RIC-9, § 3.0.

²⁹ Australian Communications and Media Authority (ACMA), *Amateur Radio Call Sign Policy* (Sept. 2024), https://www.acma.gov.au/sites/default/files/2024-09/Amateur%20radio%20call%20sign%20policy_September%202024.pdf (last visited Sept. 16, 2026).

³⁰ ACMA, *Amateur Radio-Related Fees* ("Fees from 9 August 2025": "special event, contest or VK0 or VK9 call sign: \$56"; "reassignment of call sign: special event call sign: \$36"; "contest call sign: \$16"), <https://www.acma.gov.au/amateur-radio-related-fees> (last visited Sept. 16, 2026).

Country	Regulator	Administration model	Format	Typical duration	Fee
Germany	Bundesnetzagentur (BNetzA)	Issued directly by BNetzA on a defined application form ³¹	Prefix (e.g., DA0/DK0/DL0/DR0) plus a 4-to-7-character suffix ("4-7-stelliges Sonderrufzeichen")	Up to one year, non-renewable	EUR 39.00 ³²
Ireland	Commission for Communications Regulation (ComReg)	Issued directly by ComReg ³³	ComReg's own licensing guidelines state that "distinctive call signs — which may not necessarily comply with the normal rules — may be issued by ComReg for special event stations"	Days to one week of use; licence valid up to 12 months	Not confirmed

³¹ Bundesnetzagentur, *Antrag auf Zuteilung eines 4-7-stelligen Sonderrufzeichens*, Ref. 225 (Feb. 2025), https://www.bundesnetzagentur.de/DE/Fachthemen/Telekommunikation/Frequenzen/SpezielleAnwendungen/Amateurfunk/_DL/Antrag_Sonderrufzeichen.pdf (last visited Sept. 16, 2026).

³² Besondere Gebührenverordnung des Bundesministeriums für Digitales und Verkehr für telekommunikationsrechtliche Tätigkeiten (BMDVTKBGebV), Anlage (zu § 2 Absatz 1), Abschnitt 4 (Amateurfunkgesetz und Amateurfunkverordnung), item 2.4 ("Zuteilung eines Klubstationsrufzeichens nach § 14 Absatz 1 AFuV mit einem aus vier bis sieben Zeichen bestehenden Suffix," EUR 39.00), <https://www.gesetze-im-internet.de/bmdvtkbgebv/anlage.html> (last visited Sept. 16, 2026). The special event call sign (Sonderrufzeichen) is administered as a temporary club station assignment under AFuV § 14(1), *see* note 31, *supra*, so this item's four-to-seven-character-suffix club station fee applies to it.

³³ Commission for Communications Regulation (ComReg), *Amateur Station Licence Guidelines*, ComReg Document 09/45R5 (2023), <https://www.comreg.ie/media/2023/05/ComReg-0945R5.pdf> (last visited Sept. 16, 2026).

Country	Regulator	Administration model	Format	Typical duration	Fee
Japan	Ministry of Internal Affairs and Communications (MIC), with JARL support ³⁴	Licensed directly to the sponsoring organization by MIC	"8J" or "8N" prefixes with suffix formats ranging from 2x1 to 2x5 (e.g., "8J2JAPAN" for major national events)	Tied to event period	Standard station licensing fee schedule (no separate memorial-station fee category) ³⁵

³⁴ Ministry of Internal Affairs and Communications (Japan), Radio Use Portal, *About So-Called Memorial Stations* (いわゆる記念局について) ("A so-called memorial station is an amateur station operated using a special call sign appropriate to an event, by which the event can be commemorated and its significance publicized, and which has considerable public-interest value contributing to increased understanding of amateur radio and its sound popularization and development[;] . . . an amateur station operated for a temporary and provisional purpose in connection with the holding of an event.") (translation by Petitioner), <https://www.tele.soumu.go.jp/j/others/amateur/confirmation/memorial/index.htm> (last visited Sept. 16, 2026); *see also* Japan Amateur Radio League (JARL), *Expo 2025 Special Station Information*, https://www.jarl.org/English/8_info/expo2025.html (last visited Sept. 16, 2026).

³⁵ Ministry of Internal Affairs and Communications (Japan), Hokkaido Bureau of Telecommunications, *Amateur Radio Station Fees* (effective Oct. 1, 2025) (standard new-station license application fee of ¥2,750 (electronic) / ¥4,530 (paper) for stations of 50 watts or less; no separate fee category for memorial (special event) stations, which are licensed under this same general station-license fee schedule), <https://www.soumu.go.jp/soutsu/hokkaido/E/Ama/tesuuryou.htm> (last visited Sept. 16, 2026).

19. Three features of this comparative practice are notable. First, every jurisdiction listed retains the same administrative safeguards the Commission already relies on domestically for the 1x1 system — issuance (directly or through a delegated coordinator) by the licensing authority, a fixed and limited period of validity, and a requirement that the temporary call sign be used only for the stated event. Second, none of these jurisdictions has reported that longer special event formats have caused interference, database confusion, or misidentification problems; to the contrary, several (the United Kingdom's "Special SES" format and Japan's practice for milestone national events) were adopted specifically to allow the call sign itself to communicate the anniversary or event being commemorated — the very flexibility the current U.S. 1x1 format forecloses. Third, some of these administrations give contest operation distinct treatment, separate from special event use generally. Australia charges a separate "contest call sign" reassignment fee (AUD \$16) apart from its "special event call sign" reassignment fee (AUD \$36).³⁶ Canada takes a related but more case-by-case approach: RIC-9 provides that "[c]ertain annual amateur radio contests may be considered as significant events" eligible for a Category IV special call sign, with eligibility "determined in consultation with the Canadian National Amateur Radio Society," rather than through a separate fee schedule.³⁷ The United States has no comparable dedicated contest call sign category or contest-eligibility pathway of any kind. In practice, U.S. amateurs seeking a distinctive, memorable call sign for contest operation instead rely on the existing club station and vanity call sign systems — the same permanent sequential/vanity pool this Petition's proposed special event format is specifically designed not to draw from, *see* paragraph 9,

³⁶ *See* note 30, *supra*.

³⁷ RIC-9, § 2.3 ("Certain annual amateur radio contests may be considered as significant events for which requests for special call signs under Category IV may be approved. Contests for which special event call signs are requested will be considered and their eligibility will be determined in consultation with the Canadian National Amateur Radio Society."), <https://ised-isde.canada.ca/site/spectrum-management-telecommunications/en/licences-and-certificates/radiocom-information-circulars-ric/ric-9-call-sign-policy-and-special-event-prefixes> (last visited Sept. 16, 2026).

supra. Forming a club for that purpose is an established practice: Part 97 permits a club to hold a club station license through a license trustee and to apply for a vanity call sign for that station.³⁸ U.S. contest operators also use the existing 1x1 special event system, but only incidentally: ARRL, one of the Commission-certified special event call sign coordinators, advises that the 1x1 system "[is] not intended for the exclusive ability to have a short call sign during an upcoming amateur radio operating event or contest," although a 1x1 call sign coordinated for a qualifying event "can certainly be used for any Amateur Radio operating purpose during the coordinated time period," including a contest that happens to fall within it.³⁹ Petitioner accordingly asks the Commission to make the extended format proposed in this Petition available for contest operation as well, whether or not a contest coincides with a special event, as discussed in paragraph 21, *infra*.

VI. THE PROPOSED RULE SERVES THE PUBLIC INTEREST AND ALIGNS UNITED STATES PRACTICE WITH THE REST OF THE WORLD

20. The Commission's 1997 order confined special event call signs to the 1x1 block because any longer or more available format would necessarily be "taken from the sequential and vanity call sign systems, thus denying them to amateur operators who want them assigned to their primary and club stations."⁴⁰ That scarcity concern does not apply here. This Petition does not ask the Commission to draw new special event call signs from the sequential or vanity pools. It asks the Commission to authorize a **second, separately defined, coordinator-administered special event format** — for example, a "1x2" or short alphanumeric-suffix format analogous to Canada's four-character special event suffixes or Germany's four-to-seven

³⁸ 47 C.F.R. §§ 97.5, 97.17 (club station eligibility and license trustee requirements), 97.19 (vanity call sign system); ARRL, *Club Station FAQ*, <https://www.arrl.org/club-station-faq> (last visited Sept. 16, 2026); ARRL, *Club Call Signs*, <http://www.arrl.org/club-call-signs> (last visited Sept. 16, 2026).

³⁹ ARRL, *1x1 Special Event Call Signs* (1x1 Special Event Call Sign Assignment Criteria), <https://www.arrl.org/special-event-call-signs> (last visited Sept. 16, 2026).

⁴⁰ See note 11, *supra*.

character suffixes — issued and tracked through the same certified special event call sign database coordinators that have administered the 1x1 system without reported difficulty for nearly thirty years, and subject to the same hourly self-identification safeguard already codified at 47 C.F.R. § 97.119(d). That extended suffix should be permitted to include numerals, not letters alone. ITU Radio Regulations No. 19.68 itself defines the standard amateur call sign's trailing character group as consisting of "not more than four characters, the last of which shall be a letter" — characters, not letters — and No. 19.68A's special-occasion exception removes only the four-character length limit, not that character-composition rule.⁴¹ Other administrations already rely on this to let a special event call sign numerically commemorate the occasion itself: the United Kingdom's extended "Special SES" format is used to produce call signs such as "GB100XYZ," embedding the anniversary number directly in the suffix.⁴² Petitioner accordingly proposes that the extended U.S. suffix likewise permit any combination of letters and numerals, provided the final character remains a letter, consistent with the format the Commission already uses for every other class of amateur call sign. No standard sequential or vanity call sign format — 1x2, 2x1, 2x2, 1x3, or 2x3 — ever contains more than a single numeral, so requiring the extended suffix to run at least four characters when paired with the existing single numeral, *or* requiring two or more numerals when a shorter suffix is used, is sufficient on its own to guarantee that an extended-format special event call sign can never duplicate, or be mistaken for, an existing, permanently assigned call sign; the two paths are simply two ways of reaching the same safeguard. Petitioner accordingly proposes that the extended format also be available with a two-letter prefix AA through AL, KA through KZ, NA through NZ, or WA through WZ, of the kind already used throughout the sequential and vanity call sign systems (the AA through AL block, for example, is reserved for Amateur Extra Class licensees), and not only with the existing single-letter K, N, or W prefix, so long as any call sign using that two-letter prefix likewise

⁴¹ See note 23, *supra*.

⁴² See note 25, *supra*.

contains two or more numerals. This preserves the collision-avoidance rationale that makes reuse of the existing 1x1 block administratively simple even as it meaningfully expands the pool of available special event call signs beyond what the single-letter K, N, or W prefix alone can offer. The scale of that expansion is substantial. The 1x1 block contains 750 call signs. Counting only call signs of seven or fewer characters, the extended formats proposed here⁴³ would make 1,441,620,000 call signs available, more than 1.9 million times as many, and call signs of five or fewer characters alone would number 495,000, or 660 times the size of the entire 1x1 block (Table 2).⁴⁴

Table 2. Call Signs Available Under the 1x1 Format and the Proposed Extended Formats

Total length (characters)	1x1 format	Proposed format (A)	Proposed format (B)	Total, proposed formats
3	750	—	—	—
4	—	7,500	—	7,500
5	—	262,500	225,000	487,500
6	—	32,156,250	7,875,000	40,031,250

⁴³ The extended formats are set out in full in the proposed rule text in Section VII, *infra*. Format (A) is the single-letter prefix K, N, or W followed by either (i) a single numeral and a suffix of four or five characters, or (ii) two or more numerals and a suffix of one or more characters (for example, K1ANNIV, K100TH, or K100A). Format (B) is a two-letter prefix AA through AL, KA through KZ, NA through NZ, or WA through WZ, followed by two or more numerals and a suffix of one or more characters (for example, AA100A or AA100ANNIV). In both formats, the suffix may combine the letters A through W, Y, and Z with the numerals 0 through 9, and its last character must be a letter.

⁴⁴ Petitioner's calculation from the proposed rule text in Section VII, *infra*. Each character after the prefix and the required numerals may be any of 35 symbols (the 25 letters A through W, Y, and Z, and the 10 numerals 0 through 9), and the final character must be one of the 25 letters. Format (A) uses the 3 prefixes K, N, and W. Format (B) uses the 90 two-letter prefixes AA through AL (12), and KA through KZ, NA through NZ, and WA through WZ (26 each). Call signs that satisfy both alternatives within format (A) are counted once. The proposed formats set no maximum length, so Table 2 stops at seven characters. The 1x1 figure (3 prefixes × 10 numerals × 25 letters) matches the Commission's own count of "750 one-by-one call signs." See note 9, *supra*.

Total length (characters)	1x1 format	Proposed format (A)	Proposed format (B)	Total, proposed formats
7	—	1,125,468,750	275,625,000	1,401,093,750
Total	750	1,157,895,000	283,725,000	1,441,620,000

21. The extended format should also be available for amateur radio contest operation, whether or not the contest coincides with an event of special significance. This would not be a separate call sign category. It would be a permitted use of the same extended-format call signs, drawn from the same common data base, available even when the licensee's only purpose is to operate in a contest. Other administrations already treat contests as occasions warranting a temporary call sign: Australia maintains a distinct contest call sign category,⁴⁵ and Canada allows certain annual contests to qualify for a special call sign.⁴⁶ In the United States, by contrast, a special event call sign may be used in a contest only incidentally, when the contest happens to fall within the dates of a separately qualifying special event.⁴⁷ An operator who wants a distinctive call sign for a contest itself must instead form a club and obtain a permanent club or vanity call sign drawn from the same sequential and vanity pools that the Commission's 1997 order sought to protect. Contest use of the extended format would not draw on those pools at all, because, as shown in paragraph 20, *supra*, no extended-format call sign can duplicate a permanently assigned call sign. Nor does international law stand in the way. No. 19.68A permits longer call signs "[o]n special occasions, for temporary use,"⁴⁸ and nothing in its text confines "special occasions" to commemorative events; a contest with published rules and a fixed operating period is both a special occasion and a temporary use. The same safeguards that govern special event use would apply: an extended-format call sign used for a contest would be entered on the coordinators' common data base for the contest's

⁴⁵ See note 30, *supra*.

⁴⁶ See note 37, *supra*.

⁴⁷ See note 39, *supra*.

⁴⁸ See note 4, *supra*.

operating period only, and the station would continue to transmit its assigned call sign at least once per hour under 47 C.F.R. § 97.119(d).

22. Adopting such a rule would:

- a. Bring United States practice into direct alignment with the United Kingdom, Canada, Australia, Germany, Ireland, and Japan, each of which already permits longer, more descriptive special event call signs administered under comparable safeguards;
- b. Exercise, rather than fall short of, the flexibility the ITU Radio Regulations already extend to member administrations under No. 19.68A;
- c. Allow U.S. amateur clubs and event organizers to select call signs that meaningfully identify the anniversary, exposition, or commemorated event — for example, a call sign incorporating an anniversary year, as is now common practice among UK and Japanese special event stations — improving public recognition and outreach value of the amateur service;
- d. Let U.S. contest operators use a temporary, distinctive call sign for a contest's operating period, even when no special event is involved, without forming a club or taking a permanent call sign out of the sequential and vanity call sign systems; and
- e. Impose no cost on, and require no change to, the existing sequential and vanity call sign systems, the existing 1x1 special event system, or the certified coordinators' existing database infrastructure, which need only be extended to track a second format.

VII. PROPOSED RULE TEXT

23. Petitioner proposes that the Commission amend 47 C.F.R. §§ 97.3(a)(11) and 97.119(d) as follows (new text underlined; this is illustrative proposed text for the Commission's consideration and further refinement in a Notice of Proposed Rulemaking):

§ 97.3 Definitions.

(a) * * *

(11) * * *

(iii) *Special event call sign system.* A system used to select from a common data base a call sign for use by an amateur station in conjunction with an event of special significance or, as provided below, an amateur radio contest. The call sign is selected by the station licensee from a list of call signs shown on a common data base coordinated, maintained and disseminated by the amateur station special event call sign data base coordinators. The call sign must have the single letter prefix K, N or W, followed by a single numeral 0 through 9, followed by a single letter A through W or Y or Z (for example K1A), or, at the option of the licensee, either of the following extended formats:

(A) The single letter prefix K, N or W, followed by either (i) a single numeral 0 through 9 and four or five characters consisting of any combination of the letters A through W, Y, or Z and the numerals 0 through 9, the last of which shall be a letter (for example K1ANNIV or K100TH), or (ii) two or more numerals 0 through 9 and one or more characters consisting of any combination of such letters and numerals, the last of which shall be a letter (for example K100A); or

(B) A two-letter prefix AA through AL, KA through KZ, NA through NZ, or WA through WZ, followed by two or more numerals 0 through 9, followed by one or more characters consisting of any combination of the letters A through W, Y, or Z and the numerals 0 through 9, the last of which shall be a letter (for example AA100A or AA100ANNIV);

subject to such limits on duration and availability as the Commission may by Public Notice prescribe. A call sign in either extended format may also be used in conjunction with an amateur radio contest, whether or not the contest coincides with an event of special significance, for the operating period of

that contest as shown on the common data base. The special event call sign is substituted for the call sign shown on the station license grant while the station is transmitting. The FCC will issue public announcements detailing the procedures of the special event call sign system.

§ 97.119 Station identification.

(d) When transmitting in conjunction with an event of special significance or, for a call sign in an extended format authorized under § 97.3(a)(11)(iii), an amateur radio contest, a station may substitute for its assigned call sign a special event call sign, in either format authorized under § 97.3(a)(11)(iii), as shown for that station for that period of time on the common data base coordinated, maintained and disseminated by the special event call sign data base coordinators. Additionally, the station must transmit its assigned call sign at least once per hour during such transmissions.

24. Petitioner defers to the Commission and its certified special event call sign coordinators on the precise suffix-length limits, database mechanics, and any transition period, as well as on how "amateur radio contest" should be defined for this purpose (for example, an operating event with published rules and a fixed operating period) and whether the same extended-format call sign may be reserved for the same contest in successive years, and welcomes a Notice of Proposed Rulemaking inviting comment on these implementation details.

VIII. CONCLUSION

25. For the foregoing reasons, Petitioner respectfully requests that the Commission institute a rulemaking proceeding to amend 47 C.F.R. §§ 97.3(a)(11)(iii) and 97.119(d) to authorize an additional, longer special event amateur radio call sign format, that may be used for special events and, whether or not a special event is involved, for amateur radio contests,

as set forth above, in order to bring United States practice into alignment with the ITU Radio Regulations and with the practice of comparable foreign administrations.

Respectfully submitted,
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[Date to be added prior to filing]